

RUSSELL REIGNS IN REGULATION RESET

Mercedes draws first blood
as Ferrari lets a golden opportunity slip.

Anish Pathiyil

anish.p@thehindu.co.in

2026 is a new genesis for Formula One. The latest regulations have thrust both the teams and the drivers into an unknown realm. But one aspect seems to have carried on from yesteryear — Ferrari's strategic indecisions.

When George Russell (**left**) put his Mercedes on pole position at the Albert Park circuit in Melbourne on Saturday by eight-tenths of a second, memories of the Silver Arrows' dominance of the hybrid era (2014-2021) came hurtling back. It seemed the Brackley-based outfit had left its rivals scrambling behind heading into the season-opening Australian Grand Prix.

But when the lights went out, Charles Leclerc's rip-roaring start temporarily threatened to humble this expected hegemony. Starting fourth on the grid, the scarlet Ferrari zoomed off the line and was ahead of the leading pack before Turn 1. The next few laps saw the lead change hands seven times between the Monegasque driver and Russell, with the duo looking to outsmart one another while relying on the new battery-powered thrusts of speed.

The tight battle at the top and the continuous exchange of positions ensured the pair's teammates, Andrea Kimi Antonelli and Lewis Hamilton, could close in and make it a four-way fight. But that was until the Virtual Safety Car (VSC) was triggered on lap 11 when Isack Hadjar's engine gave up on his Red Bull debut.

The medium tyres were only halfway through their shelf life, but Mercedes hit the reset button and opted to pit both its cars. The Ferrari garage, too, had the opportunity to cut down on the time loss in a pit stop, but opted against the move.

Hamilton was quick to radio in and tell his engineer that at least one of the cars should have been brought in.

Another opportunity opened itself a few laps later when Valtteri Bottas had to park his Cadillac on the grass in the American outfit's first race in the top tier of single-seater racing. Unfortunately for the Prancing Horse, Lady Luck wasn't smiling on them. The second VSC was triggered after the two Ferrari cars had crossed the pit lane line, and by the time they could come around again, the pit entry had been closed while Bottas' car was wheeled back to a position of safety. Leclerc and Hamilton were then forced to complete their mandatory stop under green-flag conditions.

With Mercedes opting to go for a one-stop strategy despite pitting its drivers early in the race,